

Just fine, thanks. What can I do for you today?

Dr. MacIntyre, many physicians I know feel they are paying too much of their income in taxes. I'm calling today to ask you what you're currently doing to ease the tax bite.

Ease the tax bite . . . hmm . . . well, of course, some of my funds go into my retirement account. That's tax-deferred . . . and my accountant has really been after me about buying municipal bonds, but I just haven't moved on that yet. Listen, I'd like to talk to you about this, but I have a patient on the way in. Can you get back to me?

THINK UP A CLOSING FOR THIS EXERCISE

This sort of practice went on for several hours a day. Since I came in at the end of a three-week session, these trainees were already adept at dialogue. Some had gone beyond the written scripts and could improvise their own openings and closings. They'd learned a new skill called "overcoming stalls and objections." They'd learned how to ask open-ended questions that get the client talking ("What do you think?" "How does that grab you?" "What is your feeling about that?") as opposed to closed-ended questions that allow the client to avoid conversation with yes or no answers. They'd been taught "responding to initial resistance during a sales call." They'd studied the "skill of acknowledging"; "probing for client feedback"; the "skill of bridging" ("earlier, you mentioned . . .").

I also sat in at Prudential-Bache and found their recruits just as well versed in dialogue, though some of the vocabulary was different. There, they talked about "restating the need," "avoiding bunched objections," "identifying the buy signals," "supporting on the same level," and "prospecting for gold in the client's words." Also, they had an elaborate system for classifying clients, which I copied from the manual as follows:

A "lead" is a piece of information. A "prospect" is a "lead" with a voice or a face attached to it. Once you have said hello and have obtained a response, the "lead" becomes a "prospect." A "prospect" becomes a "qualified